



Beginning 3rd Position Blues

The Juke Joint Trail — Getting Started

Third position is the home of the moody, minor-leaning blues sound on the diatonic harmonica. On a standard Richter-tuned harp, 3rd position sits a whole tone above the key of the harp — an A harp in 3rd position plays in B minor, which is exactly what we're using for the Telephone Blues jam track at the end of this lesson. The root note lives on draw 1, draw 4 and draw 8, and the natural mode you'll hear is Dorian: dark, hollow, slightly lonesome, and right at home over a slow blues or a minor groove.

Where 2nd position is built around the dominant, draw-heavy, shouting blues sound, 3rd position leans into something more vocal and brooding. It's superb for slow blues, minor blues, train numbers and atmospheric instrumental playing. Most of the bending work moves from the blow notes (as in 1st) and the low-draw bends (as in 2nd) onto the middle and upper draw bends — particularly draw 6 — which is why we spend real time on those exercises below.

Famous 3rd Position to listen to

- **Telephone Blues** — George "Harmonica" Smith. The classic slow-blues template for 3rd position; we'll use Smith's iconic intro lick as Ex 10.
- **Cristo Redentor** — Charlie Musselwhite's haunting reading of the Donald Byrd tune. A masterclass in 3rd position phrasing, long tones and dynamics.
- **Blowin' the Family Jewels** — George Smith / William Clarke-style tour de force in 3rd, full of octave work and tongue-blocked attack — the territory the low-octave exercises are pointing you toward.

How to use this lesson

Each exercise below has its tab on this page and a matching audio reference inside the lesson folder, so you can hear how each one should sound. Work the mid octave first — it's the friendliest place to start in 3rd position — then move to the low octave when the bends feel reliable. When you're ready to put it all together, drop the Telephone Blues jam track on and use these scales and movements as your vocabulary.



Mid Octave

Holes 4–8

The friendliest octave to start in for 3rd position. The root sits on draw 4 and most of the bends here are forgiving. Aim for clean, ringing draw notes before you push the bends in.

Ex 1. Minor Pentatonic — Mid Octave

-4 -5 +6 -6 +7 -8

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex1-minor-pent-mid-oct.mp3](#)

Ex 2. Flow Minor Pent

Flow -4 -5 +6 -6 +7 -8 +7 -6 +6 -5 -4

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex2-minor-pent-mid-flow.mp3](#)

Ex 3. Blues Scale — Mid Oct

-4 -5 +6 -'6 -6 +7 -8

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex3-blues-scale-mid.mp3](#)

Ex 4. Flow Mid Oct Blues

4 -5 +6 -'6 -6 +7 -8 +7 -6 -'6 +6 -5 -4

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex4-blues-scale-mid-flow.mp3](#)

Ex 5. Blues with Dirt

-1/4 -2/5 +3/6 -'6 -6(7) +4/7 -4/8

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex5-blues-mid-dirt.mp3](#)

Ex 6. Blues with Dirt — Flow

-1/4 -2/5 +3/6 -'6 -6(7) +4/7 -4/8 +4/7 -6(7) -'6 +3/6 -2/5 -1/4

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex6-blues-mid-dirt-flow.mp3](#)



Low Octave

Holes 1–4

Where 3rd position really starts to growl. The deep draw bends on 2 and 3 are the expressive heart of this position — take your time getting them in tune. Adding the octaves (low note + draw 4) opens up that fat, full Smith / Clarke sound.

Ex 7. Low Octave Movement + Flow

-1 -"2 +3 -'''3 +4 -4

Flow=. -1 -"2 +3 -'''3 +4 -4 +4 -'"3 +3 -"2 -1

Add Octaves on -/+4:

-1 -"2 +3 -'''3 +1/4 -1/4

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex7-low-octave-movement.mp3](#)

Ex 8. Full Blues Scale — Low Octave

-1 -"2 +3 -'"3 -"3 +4 -14

Flow:

-1 -"2 +3 -'"3 -"3 +4 -4 +4 -"3 -'"3 +3 -"2 -1

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex8-blues-low-full.mp3](#)

Ex 9. Full Blues Scale — Lower & Mid Octave (Combined)

(combined run — listen to the audio for phrasing)

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex9-blues-low-and-mid.mp3](#)

Ex 10. Telephone Blues — George Harmonica Smith Intro

-1 -"2 -1/4..... -4+4 -'"3+3 -"2 -1 -1/4.....

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-ex10-telephone-blues-intro.mp3](#)

Jam Track — Telephone Blues

Slow blues in B, played with an A harp in 3rd position. Use Ex 1–9 as your vocabulary and bring in the Smith intro from Ex 10 over the head. Start sparse — long tones, draw 4 as home — and build from there.

audio: [tracks/3rd-position-telephone-blues-jam-b.mp3](#)

Practice suggestion

Five focused minutes on each is worth more than half an hour of skimming. A useful order: Ex 1 → Ex 3 (clean mid-octave shapes), then Ex 5 → Ex 6 (add the dirt and the flow), then Ex 7 → Ex 8 (the low octave with the deep bends), then Ex 9 to join the two octaves up, and finally Ex 10 over the jam track. When the bends feel reliable, start improvising — pick two notes, make a phrase, leave space, repeat it, then change one note. The rest is ear and time on the harp.